

Basanite Marketing Strategy

TLDR

Core Problem

Basanite is facing a category-creation challenge, not a product marketing challenge. The market has not yet found the right name for Basanite's service, and "AI interviews" are already stigmatized in buyers' minds (associated with cheap resume screening and chatbot-style testing). The company must establish a new cognitive framework before competitors define it.

Three-Phase Marketing Strategy

Phase 1: Own the Problem Narrative

Sell the "crisis" before selling the product.

Use long-form research reports to build thought leadership (in partnership with academic institutions).

Target audience: CHROs, Heads of Talent, CTOs.

The founder should become the originator of new concepts such as "interview preparation bias" and "measurement gaps."

Phase 2: Prove the Mechanism

B2B procurement is driven by risk aversion, not price.

Build a case study engine with real data from large and mid-sized clients (e.g., reduced hiring time, improved quality).

Strengthen academic validation and third-party certification (a major competitive moat).

Offer free or pilot programs to SMEs to generate word-of-mouth and convert into enterprise clients.

Phase 3: Sales-Assisted Expansion

Use account-based marketing (ABM) to target the top 200 enterprises.

Focus on penetrating recruitment process outsourcing (RPO) firms—winning one can unlock dozens of enterprise clients.

Main Body

Definition of Terms

Challenger Brand is a mindset and competitive stance. It's for markets where a category already exists and has established leaders. The challenger doesn't have the biggest budget or the most distribution, so it wins by reframing the terms of competition, making the incumbent's strength look like a weakness, and building an identity that is defined in opposition to the leader.

Classic examples include Oatly positioning dairy milk as industrial and harmful, and Brewdog positioning mainstream lager as bland and corporate. The challenger wins by making the market uncomfortable with the status quo and presenting itself as the honest, principled, or disruptive alternative. The category already has a name. The buyer already has a mental shelf for the product. The challenger is just fighting for a different position on that shelf.

Category Creation is a market strategy instead of merely a stance. It's for situations where the product doesn't fit cleanly into an existing mental shelf, where trying to compete in an existing category would immediately disadvantage you because the incumbents own the frame. Instead of fighting for position inside someone else's category, you define a new one, give it a name, educate the market on why the old categories are insufficient, and position yourself as the obvious leader of the space you just invented. Salesforce didn't sell "better CRM software", they invented "cloud CRM" and made on-premise software the enemy. The goal is to be the only name on the shelf, because you built the shelf.

The key practical difference is what you're fighting. A challenger brand fights the leader. A category creator fights the old way of thinking. One requires a compelling enemy (the incumbent). The other requires a compelling villain (the outdated paradigm).

Where Basanite Sits

Basanite needs both strategies, sequenced. Right now the market doesn't have a name for what Basanite does. "AI interviewing" already means cheap screening bots in most buyers' minds, which is the wrong shelf entirely. So the first move has to be category creation: name the problem ("the measurement gap", "interview preparedness bias"), establish that the existing tools such as coding tests, structured interviews and take-homes are all solving the wrong problem, and make Basanite the obvious answer to the newly named category.

Once the category has traction and imitators inevitably appear, then the challenger brand posture becomes useful. Basanite can define itself against the superficial competitors who copied the surface without the underlying assessment philosophy. But leading with challenger brand now would mean picking a fight with HireVue or Greenhouse, which would drag Basanite into a category comparison it doesn't want to be in.

The sequencing matters enormously. Category first, challenger second.

The Investor Constraint

Investors at pre-stage aren't buying a proven market. They're buying a credible theory of how you'll win, plus early signals that the theory is already working. What they actually need to see is three things, in order of weight: that the problem is real and urgent, that the founding team can own the narrative in the space, and that early commercial traction, however small, validates demand. Everything in the marketing strategy must be optimised to generate those three signals as fast as possible.

Phase 1 - Own One Flagship Insight

Thought leadership is the right instinct, but long-form research reports take too long to gain traction before a raise. The goal of Phase 1 is not to educate the whole market, but rather to generate visible proof that the market responds to Basanite's framing.

The mechanism is a single flagship insight: one counterintuitive, quotable claim that travels through the right communities on its own. Something like "technical hiring selects for the skills AI is replacing fastest": sharp enough to provoke, true enough to defend, and simple enough for an investor to repeat in their own words to another investor. One LinkedIn post from a credible founder that generates 50,000

impressions and 200 comments from CHROs and engineering leaders is worth more in a pitch meeting than a whitepaper nobody has read yet.

Alongside the flagship insight, the founding team needs to become visibly credible in the space through three to five speaking slots at the right events: SHRM, RecFest, SaaStr, and talent acquisition communities on LinkedIn. The goal is not coverage; it is for investors to encounter Basanite's framing independently, from multiple directions, before the pitch arrives.

The third element is establishing direct relationships with two or three academic voices who can publicly validate the assessment methodology. Independent third-party validation of assessment quality is extraordinarily rare in this space. Even early-stage association with credible researchers signals to investors that the product is built on a defensible intellectual foundation, not a thin AI wrapper.

Ideally by the end of Phase 1, investors should find Basanite's language such as "measurement gap", "interview preparedness bias" are already circulating in the talent communities they monitor.

Phase 2 · Paying Design Partners, Not Freemium

Freemium signals uncertainty about value. For investor purposes, paying customers, even at heavily discounted rates, signal something free users never can. The target is five to ten paying design partners drawn from Tier 1 or Tier 3 companies who are using the product in live hiring rounds and generating quotable outcomes.

These are not beta users but named references. Each design partner should be selected for their ability to produce investor-legible proof: not "customers love us" but "company X ran 40 assessments, advanced 8 candidates, and their hiring manager said Basanite surfaced things a phone screen would never have caught." Specific, attributable, and concrete.

The Prospect Intelligence Agent's immediate job in this phase is not to build a 200-company pipeline. It is to identify the ten highest-fit design partners and get them signed before the raise closes. The targeting criteria should be ruthlessly narrow: companies actively hiring at volume, recently funded, and without a dedicated ATS, which is the profile where Basanite's value is most immediate and most legible.

Phase 3 · Narrative Acceleration

With a flagship insight circulating and design partners generating early outcomes, Phase 3 converts those inputs into investor-facing proof and prepares the raise.

The Community Listening Agent becomes the most strategically valuable tool in this phase, not primarily for engagement, but for market intelligence. **Investors want to see that the founding team understands the conversation happening in the market better than anyone else.** A founder who walks into a pitch and says "here are the twelve most common complaints about HireVue on Blind in the last ninety days, and here is exactly how Basanite addresses each one" is a founder who looks like they are already winning the category.

The Narrative Monitoring Agent tracks every time a journalist, investor, or influential voice publishes something about AI hiring, technical screening, or hiring bias, and drafts a reactive response or outreach for the founder within hours. At pre-stage, speed of narrative response is disproportionately valuable. One well-timed response to a high-profile piece on AI hiring can do more for investor awareness than months of scheduled content.

Design partner outcomes are formalised into a small number of structured case stories, each built around a concrete, measurable result and a named company willing to be referenced. These are the proof layer for the raise: honest, specific accounts of what happened when real companies used the product in live hiring.

Phase 4 · Sales-Assisted Land and Expand

Possible Agentic Solutions

Narrative Monitoring Agent, build first

Monitors publication, post, and conversation where AI hiring, technical screening, or hiring bias is discussed: journalists, investors, influential practitioners, academic preprints. When relevant content appears, it drafts a reactive response or outreach for the founding team

within hours. The goal is to make Basanite's voice part of every significant conversation in the space, not as a scheduled broadcaster but as a fast-reacting participant. At pre-stage this is the highest-leverage marketing tool available.

Community Listening Agent, build second

Monitors Reddit (r/recruiting, r/cscareerquestions), Blind, LinkedIn, and relevant Slack communities for conversations about bad interview experiences, AI cheating in hiring, frustration with existing tools, or questions about what good technical assessment looks like. In this phase it serves two functions: surfacing engagement opportunities for the founding team, and generating the market intelligence that makes investor conversations sharper and more credible.

Prospect Intelligence Agent, build third, narrow the brief

Connected to LinkedIn, job posting data, and funding databases. In this phase its only job is to identify the ten highest-fit design partner candidates and produce personalised outreach for each. The broader pipeline-building function comes later. Targeting criteria: actively posting five or more technical roles, recently funded at Series B or later, no dedicated ATS detected.

Content and Thought Leadership Agent, build fourth

Monitors talent acquisition forums, LinkedIn conversations, earnings calls from HR tech companies, and academic preprints. Surfaces emerging narratives, drafts reactive commentary for the founders to publish within hours of relevant news, and maintains a content calendar tied to the industry event cycle. Valuable from Phase 1 but lower priority than the first three.